

ANI

FRIENDS AGAIN Nitish Kumar with J.P. Nadda and Chirag Paswan after taking oath as Bihar CM for the ninth time in Patna, Jan. 28

THAT I.N.D.I.A. ALLIES DID NOT CONSIDER HIM WORTHY OF A NATIONAL ROLE AGGRIEVED NITISH AND PUSHED HIM INTO THE BJP'S ARMS, SAY SOURCES

12-15 per cent of the vote share, including from Nitish's own caste—the Kurmis (3 per cent). With him gone and Mamata going her own way, I.N.D.I.A. will face an uphill task to improve its tally from the current 79 out of 313 seats in these 10 states.

Things aren't going well in other states either. In Punjab, which has 13 Lok Sabha seats, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has decided against any seat-sharing agreement with the Congress. In Jharkhand, which has 14 Lok Sabha seats, the existing alliance between the Hemant Soren-led Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), RJD and Congress may disintegrate with the Enforcement Directorate arresting the chief minister on January 31. In Kerala, which has 20 Lok Sabha seats, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) and the CPI (M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) remain at cross-purposes. In Maharashtra, with 48 Lok Sabha seats, the split in the Shiv Sena and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) has considerably weakened the I.N.D.I.A. constituents; speculation is rife that powerful sub-regional satraps of the Congress—two from Marathwada and one from Vidarbha—may join the BJP by the end of February, coinciding with the Rajya Sabha election. Uttar Pradesh, which sends 80 legislators to the lower house, has been somewhat of a saving grace for I.N.D.I.A., but even here the Samajwadi Party (SP) has offered the Congress only 11 seats; the Grand Old Party has yet to reciprocate. The SP has even fielded candidates from 16 seats, including in four seats that the Congress wanted. That leaves only Tamil Nadu, which has 39 seats, where the alliance between the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Congress seems settled, with the national party agreeing to the nine seats offered.

So, what went wrong?

THE CONGRESS COMPLEX

Much of I.N.D.I.A.'s success rested on the ability of the Congress—the only pan-India formation in the alliance—to draw up meaningful seat-sharing arrangements with allies. Nitish had batted for the national party to remain the pivot of the alliance, but the course of action was clear—the Congress would focus on states where it was in direct contest with the BJP and leave the other states to the dominant regional player. However, rather than rise to the occasion and play a unifying role, the Congress proved unrealistic in its demand for seats, which as JD(U)'s K.C. Tyagi alleged, was disproportionate in the states where it is not strong.

Behind the pushback from the regional parties is the past performance of the Congress. In the 2020 Bihar assembly polls, for example, Tejashwi Yadav's spirited campaigning had brought the RJD within striking distance of forming a government. But it was the dismal show of the Congress—which won only 19 of the 70 seats it was given to contest—that put paid to their chances.

In West Bengal, Mamata said she waited 210 days since I.N.D.I.A. first met in June 2023 for the Congress to take a decision on seat-sharing. And when it did get down to it, the Grand Old Party demanded 10-12 seats. Mamata,